never know, and, given his mocking self-promotion as ‘a fat lad’, we probably shouldn’t ask. His legend is justifiably secure.

To give him his due, KP worked on his batting with greater intensity. He lacked Freddie’s common touch, though the stereotype of the Northern lad who loves a pint was never entirely accurate. Freddie knew the power of his personality and remains a brilliant self-promoter. Good luck to the guy. He certainly helped me at a pivotal moment in my career.

I was one of three debutants in Nagpur, alongside Ian Blackwell and Monty Panesar. In one sense I had little to lose, because I was just off the plane. In another, as I walked out alongside Straussy, I knew I was about to confront the ultimate test of an English opening batsman, dealing with spin almost from the get-go.

The rhythm of batting in India is so different. Facing world-class spinners with men around the bat, especially once the ball loses its hardness, requires patience and focus. The subcontinent rarely offers the respite of an occasional nick through third man to get going, as is the case when you open in more accustomed circumstances, against pace bowling.

There’s little certainty about conditions, but the process is regimented, which suited my character. Goochy captured the challenge perfectly, telling me ‘you have the opportunity to set the game up’. I caught myself looking down at the three lions on my shirt in wonder a few times (my promotion was too quick for it to have been inscribed with my England number, 630), but did my job, being fourth out for 60, with the score on 136.

The fourth day began with the Indians threatening to field in casual clothes unless they were paid a 130-rupee laundry allowance. It ended with me unbeaten on 104, suitably grateful that Harbhajan Singh dropped a spooned return catch when I was on 70. For good measure I had received my first marriage proposal, scrawled on a piece of cardboard.

Alice was studying in Reading. I checked.

I scored only 17 and 2 in the second Test, which we lost, and missed the third in Mumbai, which we won, through illness. I was off and running. Though I tend to think the role is over-romanticized, because we will bat with the lower order if we do our job properly, Straussy was the first of my fifteen opening partners in Test cricket.

Since my sport is a statistical smorgasbord, someone has inevitably calculated that Sunil Gavaskar holds the record with nineteen. In human terms, the list forms an interesting case study of the collateral damage